



Marathon, the Greek hoplite (heavy infantry) formation advanced head-on against a far more numerous Persian force to win an **unlikely victory**.

Chastened, the Persian expeditionary force withdrew from Greece after Marathon, but in 481 BCE **Xerxes I** (519–465 BCE) dispatched another huge Persian army, which crossed over the Hellespont (near modern-day Istanbul) and proceeded south toward Athens. Many northern Greek states chose to submit, but Athens and Sparta patched together a league of southern states. In 480 BCE, a **heroic defense** of the pass at **Thermopylae** by the Spartan king Leonidas I, in which he and all his 10,000 soldiers died, bought time for the Athenians to evacuate. The Persians burned the city, but soon after, under the command of **Themistocles** (see panel below), the Athenian fleet inflicted a serious defeat on Xerxes's naval force at **Salamis**. Further Greek



victories followed in June 479 BCE, on land at Plataea in Boeotia and at sea at Mycale off the Ionian coast. The Greeks then took the offensive, and during 478–477 BCE won a string of victories in Ionia and Cyprus, which **reversed most of the Persians' gains**.

After the initial defeats of the Persians in 480–479 BCE, Athens sought to formalize the **league of anti-Persian allies**. A treasury was set up on the island of Delos in around 477 BCE. The league's funds were to be deposited here and regular meetings were to take place. But this **Delian League** soon became little more than an Athenian empire, and Sparta and its allies refused to take part.

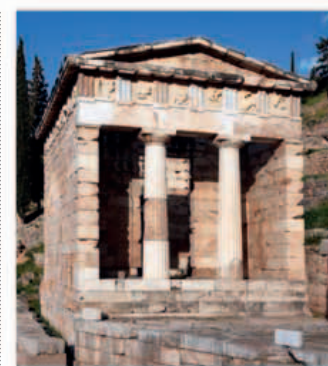
“THE GREAT STRUGGLE HAS COME.”

Herodotus, ancient Greek historian, quoting Pausanias, the Spartan commander, before the Battle of Plataea in 479 BCE; from *Histories*

THE ATHENIANS ENJOYED EARLY SUCCESS under the direction of Cimon (510–450 BCE), wresting Eion on the Strymon River (in Anatolia) from the Persians in 476 BCE and then attacking Carystos on Euboea (which had submitted to the Persians) in 470 BCE. An attempt by the island of Naxos to leave the Delian League around the same time led to an Athenian expeditionary force that powerfully suppressed the breakaway movement. In 469 BCE, Athenian forces won a great **victory over the Persians** at the Eurymedon River on the south coast of Anatolia, establishing Athenian supremacy in the Aegean.

Pericles (c. 495–429 BCE), the Athenian statesman largely responsible for making Athens the political and cultural focus of Greece, tried but failed to prosecute Cimon in 463 BCE, on a charge of having neglected a chance to conquer Macedonia. From this maneuver, **Pericles' vision** and ideas of expansion for Athens were already evident. When the leading figure among the democrats, Ephialtes, was assassinated in 461 BCE, Pericles, his protégé, swiftly took his place.

Periodically, the Persians had tried to bribe the Spartans into diversionary attacks on Athens, initially to little effect. In 464 BCE, a **revolt of the Messenian Helots** (unfree men) in the western Peloponnese further distracted the Spartans from any attempt to stem the rising power of the Delian League. The Messenians received little outside assistance,



Athenian treasury at Delos
All members of the Delian League had to deposit funds at treasuries on Delos, but the contribution of Athens was the most important.

and by 462 BCE their last stronghold at Ithome had been reduced. Soon after, open conflict broke out between Sparta and Athens and their respective allies. The **First Peloponnesian War** was inconclusive. It ended in 451 BCE with a five-year truce, extended in 446 BCE to a **Thirty Years' Peace** between the two sides.

Meanwhile, the western part of the Greek world was becoming increasingly important, marked by the **rise of the Sicilian city-state of Syracuse**. Under a series of able rulers (tyrants) that began with **Gelon** (r. 485–478 BCE) and his brother **Hieron** (r. 478–467 BCE), Syracusan forces subdued the neighboring city of Acragas and expanded territory around Catana. Although Hieron's younger brother **Thrasybulus** was driven out in 466 BCE, the Syracusans retained their dominant position in Sicily beyond the 450s BCE.

THEMISTOCLES (c. 524–460 BCE)

A clever politician and strategist, Themistocles persuaded the Athenians to use the wealth of a silver mine discovered at Laurium in 483/2 BCE to double their fleet. However, after the naval victory at Salamis, he became the object of increasing jealousy from political rivals. In about 470 BCE Themistocles was ostracized from Athens (exiled by public vote).



480 BCE Xerxes I of Persia invades Greece and burns Athens, but is defeated by Themistocles at the naval **Battle of Salamis**

479 BCE Persians are defeated at Plataea and Mycale, and withdraw from mainland Greece

478 BCE Hieron becomes Tyrant of Syracuse and defeats the Etruscans

478 BCE Athens founds the **Delian League** to counter Sparta's attempts to dominate Greece

c. 470 BCE Themistocles is ostracized from Athens

469 BCE Naxos tries to secede from the Delian League and is blockaded by Athens

464 BCE The Helots revolt against Spartan rule, but they are defeated by 462 BCE

458 BCE Athens defeats the Peloponnesian cities and Aegina is forced to join the Delian League

452 BCE A five-year truce begins between Athens and the Peloponnesians